October, noted the first reactions regarding Krenz, ‘were often characterised by consternation on the part of citizens. He is said to be a representative of the former leadership, which has landed the country in a tricky situation.’9 Speaking on FRG TV, an East Berliner in his fifties said it was ‘like replacing a lame white horse with a lame brown one’, while a spokesman for the New Forum remarked, ‘he is, after all, responsible for many things in East Germany which makes him very suspect’.10 Even the US Ambassador Richard C. Barkley said it was clear that Krenz did not represent a particularly sympathetic figure; ‘Although he was only in his late 40s [he was 52], he had been so associated with the Honecker regime that he was not looked to as a sign of change.’11

He was somewhat better than his reputation. He was basically a child of the system and he voted for the system; he expected the system to continue, and that he would naturally become the head of things. In his view that was preordained. Anyway, it became clear that there were a lot of things going on underneath him that he did not understand. It also became clear that he couldn’t control them.12